



THE LANDMINE DOES NOT RECOGNIZE PEACE

THE ANTI-PERSONNEL MINE BAN CONVENTION (1997)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Arms control

BEFORE

1992 The International Campaign to Ban Landmines (ICBL) is founded.

1995 Belgium becomes the first country in the world to ban anti-personnel mines.

1996 A ban on landmines is provisionally adopted at a conference in Ottawa, Canada, with 75 countries attending.

AFTER

1998 Landmine Monitor is formulated by the ICBL to oversee treaty compliance.

2010 The Convention on Cluster Munitions comes into force. As of 2020, 121 states have committed to its goals.

2016 A rise of 150 percent is recorded for victims of anti-personnel mines, mostly as a result of ongoing conflicts.

By the early 1990s, an estimated 110 million anti-personnel landmines (APLs) were buried in the ground across the globe. Most were left over from former conflicts in Africa, the Middle East, and Southeast Asia. Detonated by people stepping on them, they caused horrific injuries or death. The exact number of casualties is unknown, but up to 25,000 people were being killed or maimed every year as they went about regular activities such as herding animals or collecting firewood. Those who trod on the mines were not the only ones to suffer: the consequences were also devastating for families deprived of breadwinners. In conflict zones around the world, these weapons

were used in such large numbers because they are easily deployed and very cheap. On the other hand, getting rid of them is dangerous and expensive. An APL bought for \$3 (£2.50) can cost \$1,000 (£815) to remove. This was clearly an urgent and growing humanitarian crisis.

The Ottawa Treaty

A solution came in the form of the Anti-Personnel Mine Ban Convention (or Ottawa Treaty), which was adopted by 122 countries in Ottawa, Canada, in December 1997 and came into force in March 1999. By 2020, the number of countries signed up to it had increased to 164. All signatory nations made a commitment not to produce or use APLs, to destroy all stockpiled APLs within 4 years of signing, and to eliminate all minefields “under their jurisdiction or control” within 10 years of signing. The treaty encouraged international cooperation in mine clearance and medical support.

Most victims (71 percent) of anti-personnel mines are civilians. Children account for half of those. An injury that can be devastating for an adult is more often fatal for a child.

